

Jainism and Buddhism

These are non-Vedic philosophical systems that do not consider the Vedas as an authoritative text.

Jainism

Jainism's name is derived from the Sanskrit root *ji*, which means "to conquer," referring to someone who has subdued their passions.

- **Tirthankaras:** The philosophy is based on the teachings of 24 prophets or masters known as Tirthankaras, with Mahavira being the last, who lived in the 6th century BCE.
- **Sects:** After Mahavira, two main sects emerged:
 - **Svetambaras:** Focus on rituals, prayers, and social welfare.
 - **Digambaras:** Emphasize absolute renunciation and understanding of the Self.
- **Core Beliefs:**
 - **Fundamental Categories:** The philosophy identifies several fundamental categories of being: soul (Jiva), matter (Pudgala), space (Akasa), time (Kala), the principle of motion (Dharma), and the principle of rest (Adharma).
 - **Karma:** In Jainism, karma is seen as tiny particles of matter that attach to the soul (Jiva) due to passions, leading to a cycle of birth and death. The goal is to purify the soul of this karmic matter.
 - **Three Gems:** To achieve liberation, one must follow the "three gems": Right Faith, Right Knowledge, and Right Conduct.
 - **Ahimsa:** Non-violence is a crucial aspect of Right Conduct.
 - **Syadvada:** This is the theory of conditional predication, which states that our knowledge of any substance is relative and not absolute. It suggests that reality can be observed from multiple viewpoints.

Buddhism

Buddhism is founded on the teachings of Gautama Buddha and primarily focuses on the means to end individual suffering.

- **The Four Noble Truths:**

1. There is suffering.
 2. Suffering has a cause, which is "thirst" or desire.
 3. Suffering can cease by destroying desire.
 4. There is a path to end suffering.
- **The Eightfold Path:** This is the path to end suffering and includes: Right View, Right Resolve, Right Speech, Right Conduct, Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right Concentration.
 - **Cause of Suffering:** Ignorance is considered the root cause of suffering, as it leads to impressions from a previous birth, consciousness, and a thirst for enjoyment, resulting in rebirth.
 - **Nirvana:** The ultimate goal is to reach Nirvana, a state of peace and wisdom free from desires, which can be attained in this life and ends the cycle of birth and death.
 - **Schools of Buddhism:** There are two main forms: Mahayana (Northern Buddhism) and Theravada (Southern Buddhism).

Upanishads and Vedanta

The Upanishads are late Vedic and post-Vedic texts that represent a transition from ritualism to new philosophical ideas.

Upanishads

- **Content:** They focus on meditation, philosophy, consciousness, and ontological knowledge, whereas earlier Vedic texts dealt with mantras, rituals, and ceremonies.
- **Number:** About 108 Upanishads are known, with the first dozen being the oldest and most important, referred to as the *mukhya* (main) Upanishads.
 1. Rigveda - 1 (Speaks of Universal Conscious)
 2. Yajurveda – 4 (Speaks of Manifestation of Forms & Shapes)
 3. Samaveda – 2 (Speaks of Characteristics of Different forms)
 4. Atharvaveda – 3 (speaks of Application)
- **Central Concern:** Their primary goal is to understand the relationship between ritual, cosmic realities, the human body, the individual self (Ātman), and the ultimate reality (Brahman).

Vedanta

Vedanta refers to several schools of philosophy that interpret the Upanishads, the Bhagavad Gita, and the Brahmasutra in different ways. Here is a comparison of the three main schools:

Feature	Advaita Vedanta	Vishishtadvaita Vedanta	Dvaita Vedanta
Īśvara (God)	One, attribute-less (Nirguna-brahman)	One, personal God (Saguna-brahman), identified as Viṣṇu or Nārāyana	One, personal God (Saguna-brahman), identified as Viṣṇu or Hari
Jagat (Universe)	Not real, an illusory experience	Real, made of Prakṛti and Guṇas	Real, made of Prakṛti and Guṇas
Jiva-Jagat-Īśvara Relation	All are one and the same as Brahman	All are part of Īśvara; Jīva and Jagat depend on Īśvara	All are uniquely different; Jīva and Jagat depend on Īśvara
Path to Liberation	Jñāna-yoga (path of knowledge), with Karma-yoga as a prerequisite	Bhakti (devotion) and Prapatti (surrender)	Bhakti-yoga and the grace of Īśvara
Liberation	Experiencing oneness with Brahman	Attaining the feet of the Lord	Gaining knowledge of the greatness of Īśvara

Vastu Shastra

Vastu Shastra is the traditional Indian system of architecture. The process of construction involves several key roles and stages:

- **Yajamana:** The owner who initiates the construction, seeking a peaceful and prosperous dwelling.
- **Sthapati:** The architect, who must possess technical knowledge, artistic ability, and the right attitude.
- **Bhumi:** The land, which must be suitable for the intended purpose, such as a residence or palace.
- **Vastupuja:** Prayers conducted at the construction site.
- **Padavinyasa:** The layout of the building, which includes details for rooms, floors, and balconies.
- **Sutragrahin:** The surveyor or draftsman responsible for structural dimensions.
- **Takshaka & Vardhaki:** The team of contractors and skilled laborers who carry out the construction.